
Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. (for adults)

The Hackles Kit

A free kit by Competence Collective · competencecollective.org · quillsup.org · October 2026

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A plain-language adaptation of the Hackles routine for college students and the adults who work with them. About four minutes to read.

Where the idea comes from

HACKLES ARE WHAT RISE on the back of your neck when something feels off. For younger children, Hackles teaches them to notice that feeling and act on it. The adult version keeps the same four steps and drops the games. You already have the instinct. This routine gives you words and a next move.

01 Hackles up?

NOTICE THE PRICKLE. NAME what is off in one sentence, out loud if you can. "They want money before I have seen the apartment." "This call is making me hurry." "I do not know this person, and they asked for a favor."

Common prickle triggers:

- Hurry: "in two hours," "today only," "before your account closes."
- Secrecy: "do not tell your roommate," "keep this between us."
- Odd payment: gift cards, crypto, wire, a payment app with no protection.
- Too good: an easy job at a high rate, a big refund, a dream apartment at half price.
- Borrowed authority: a logo, a title, a name that sounds official.
- Strong feeling: fear, flattery, guilt, or love from someone you have never met.

The prickle proves nothing by itself, and it earns a closer look.

02 Pause

NOTHING HAS TO HAPPEN in the next five minutes. Close the tab, put the phone down, walk to the window. Money decisions can wait overnight. A real office will still be there tomorrow.

You can say this to a pushy person: "I need a little time. I will call you back."

03 Check

Confirm through a door you opened yourself:

- Type the website address, or open the official app.
- Call the number printed on your card, the college website or your own saved contacts.
- Walk to the office.
- Ask a friend to look with fresh eyes.

Replying to the same message or calling the number the message gave you is not a check, because the sender controls that door.

04 Tell

Bring in a person. Climb the Help Ladder:

1. A friend you trust.
2. An adult or an office you trust: a roommate, an RA, an advisor, [COUNSELING CENTER], [FINANCIAL AID OFFICE], [IT HELP DESK], [DEAN OF STUDENTS].
3. A formal report: the platform, the bank, [CAMPUS POLICE], the [TITLE IX OFFICE], reportfraud.ftc.gov, ic3.gov [VERIFY], and for images of a minor, the NCMEC CyberTipline.

You can start on any rung. If the first person does not help, climb to the next one. Keep climbing until someone does.

Before you tell an office, you may ask: "What would you have to share?"

Some campus offices keep what you say private and some are required to pass information on [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM for your college].

For threats and images: Stop. Save. Tell. Report.

- **Stop** replying. Do not pay. Do not delete the account or the conversation yet.
- **Save** usernames, links, dates, threats and payment demands.
- **Tell** someone you trust.
- **Report** to the platform and the right agency. StopNCII.org is for adults (you must be 18 or older now and when the image was made). Take It Down is for images made when you were under 18. Do not copy, forward or screenshot an image of a person under 18, even as proof. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]

If you were fooled anyway

IT HAPPENS TO CAREFUL people, because the people who run these schemes do it for a living. It is never your fault. In the first hour: call your bank or card issuer on the number on your card. Change passwords starting with email. Keep the messages. Tell someone. Report it so the next person gets a warning.

For people who support students

STAFF, FACULTY AND PEER educators can use the same four steps as a way to talk with a student:

- "What made your hackles go up?"
- "What would be a way to check that does not use the message you were sent?"
- "Who else could look at this with you?"
- "Would you like me to come with you?"

Then use the Say This, Not That list in the Facilitator Guide.

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Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled study. It does not replace advice from a professional.